

G08 — Modal Verbs

Les verbes modaux

 17 S4 — Cours 2	 B1	 marc.vasseur@polytech-lille.fr
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🔴 Les modaux (can, could, may, might, must, should, will, would, shall, need) modifient le sens du verbe. Pas de 'to' après eux, pas de 's' à la 3e personne.

Tableau complet des modaux

MODAL	SENS PRINCIPAL	EXEMPLE
CAN	Capacité / permission informelle	She can speak French.
COULD	Capacité passée / politesse / suggestion	He could swim when he was 5.
MAY	Possibilité (formelle) / permission formelle	It may rain. / May I leave?
MIGHT	Possibilité faible	He might be late.
MUST	Obligation forte / déduction logique (+)	You must wear a badge. / She must be tired.
HAVE TO	Obligation externe / règle	I have to submit by Monday.
SHOULD	Conseil / recommandation	You should check again.
OUGHT TO	Conseil (légèrement plus fort)	You ought to apologise.
NEEDN'T	Pas d'obligation	You needn't come early.
MUSTN'T	Interdiction absolue	You mustn't touch that wire!
WOULD	Conditionnel / politesse	I would accept if I were you.
SHALL	Suggestion / offre (Br. Eng.)	Shall we start?

MUST vs HAVE TO vs MUSTN'T vs DON'T HAVE TO

MODAL	SENS	EXEMPLE
MUST	Obligation interne (mon choix)	I must call — I feel guilty.
HAVE TO	Obligation externe (règle)	I have to wear a tie — it's the policy.
MUSTN'T	Interdiction (ne pas faire)	You mustn't park here.
DON'T HAVE TO / NEEDN'T	Pas nécessaire (mais possible)	You don't have to come — it's optional.

⚠ 'You mustn't' ≠ 'You don't have to'. Mustn't = interdit. Don't have to = pas obligatoire.

Modaux au passé

PRÉSENT	PASSÉ	SENS
must (déduction +)	must have + PP	She must have left already.
can't (impossibilité)	can't have + PP	He can't have done that.
should	should have + PP	You should have told me! (reproche)
could	could have + PP	She could have won (mais ne l'a pas fait).
might/may	might/may have + PP	He might have forgotten.
needn't	needn't have + PP	You needn't have brought food — we had enough.

🧠 **MUST = ma décision / HAVE TO = règle externe / MUSTN'T = interdit / NEEDN'T = pas obligé.**



EXERCICES GUIDÉS

Choisis et justifie le bon modal.

Série guidée A — Présent

💡 must = obligation interne / have to = règle / mustn't = interdit / should = conseil / needn't = pas oblig.

- You _____ wear a helmet in the lab — it's compulsory.
→ règle imposée → must/have to
→ _____
- You _____ touch that wire — it's live!
→ interdiction absolue
→ _____
- She _____ check her report again — there might be errors.
→ conseil
→ _____
- You _____ come if you're busy — it's optional.
→ pas d'obligation
→ _____
- He _____ be tired — he's worked 14 hours.
→ déduction logique
→ _____
- _____ I borrow your charger for a moment?
→ permission formelle
→ _____
- Students _____ use their phones during exams.
→ interdiction règlement
→ _____

→ _____

8. She _____ speak four languages fluently.

→ capacité

→ _____

9. You _____ backup your data regularly.

→ conseil fort

→ _____

10. He _____ be the new director — I saw his name on the door.

→ déduction logique

→ _____

Série guidée B — Modaux au passé

💡 Modal + have + PP pour le passé. must have = déduction / should have = reproche / can't have = impossibilité

11. She passed the exam without studying. She _____ (must / be) very smart.

→ déduction passée

→ _____

12. You _____ (should / tell) me about the problem earlier.

→ reproche sur passé

→ _____

13. He _____ (might / forget) the meeting — it's not like him.

→ possibilité passée

→ _____

14. She _____ (can't / do) that — she was abroad at the time.

→ impossibilité passée

→ _____

15. I _____ (could / finish) earlier if I had started sooner.

→ possibilité non réalisée

→ _____

16. You _____ (needn't / bring) food — we ordered catering.

→ regret d'un effort inutile

→ _____

17. She _____ (must / leave) already — her bag is gone.

→ déduction

→ _____

18. He _____ (should / apply) for that position — he'd have been perfect.

→ reproche/regret

→ _____

19. They _____ (may / receive) the email — we're not sure.

→ possibilité passée

→ _____

20. I _____ (could / do) better if I _____ (have) more data.

→ possible non réalisé

→ _____



EXERCICES — NIVEAUX A → B2+

Complète avec le modal le plus approprié.

Niveau A — Modaux de base (B1)

1. Students _____ use their phones during exams — it's strictly forbidden.

→ _____

2. You _____ submit the report by Friday — it's a hard deadline.

→ _____

3. She _____ speak English and German fluently.

→ _____

4. You _____ come early tomorrow — the meeting starts at 10.

→ _____

5. He _____ be the new director — I saw his name on the list.

→ _____

Niveau B — Nuances et modaux au passé (B1+)

6. We _____ cancel the experiment — the equipment isn't working.

→ _____

7. You _____ always backup your data — it's crucial.

→ _____

8. I _____ help you if you need it — just ask.

→ _____

9. They _____ arrive late — the traffic was terrible yesterday.

→ _____

10. She _____ have forgotten to save her work — it's all gone.

→ _____

11. You _____ eat in the lab — health regulations.

→ _____

12. I _____ study harder — I want to improve my TOEIC score.

→ _____

13. He _____ have told me — I would have helped.

→ _____

14. She _____ have passed her exam — she looks so happy!

→ _____

15. We _____ delay this decision any longer.

→ _____

Niveau C — Correction et traduction (B1+)

→ Corrige les erreurs.

16. She can to speak three languages. → _____

→ _____

17. You must to wear a badge. → _____

→ _____

18. He should have told to me. → _____

→ _____

19. She couldn't have be there — she was in Lyon. → _____

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→ _____

20. You don't must enter without permission. → _____

→ _____

→ Traduis en anglais.

21. Tu n'es pas obligé de venir si tu es occupé.

→ _____

22. Elle doit être très fatiguée — elle travaille depuis l'aube.

→ _____

23. Il aurait dû me prévenir plus tôt.

→ _____

24. Vous ne devez pas photographier dans ce laboratoire.

→ _____

25. Ils ont peut-être reçu un email mais ils n'ont pas répondu.

→ _____

Niveau D — Registre formel et nuances B2+

→ Réécris avec un modal qui exprime la même idée mais dans un registre plus ou moins formel.

26. 'You are required to submit the form.' → (informel) _____

→ _____

27. 'Perhaps she has misunderstood the brief.' → (avec modal) _____

→ _____

28. 'It is not permitted to enter the server room.' → (avec modal) _____

→ _____

29. 'I recommend that you revise your figures.' → (avec modal) _____

→ _____

30. 'It is possible that the deadline will be extended.' → (avec modal) _____

→ _____

Score : _____ / 30 points

★ ★ Bonus — Modaux dans un rapport professionnel

Complète ce paragraphe de rapport avec les modaux appropriés.

→ The system _____ (= obligation) be updated before the next audit. Several vulnerabilities _____ (= possibilité passée) have been introduced during the last patch.

Réponse : _____

→ Engineers _____ (= conseil) review the code carefully. Under no circumstances _____ (= interdiction) anyone modify the core database without authorisation.

Réponse : _____

→ The new protocol _____ (= capacité future) significantly reduce downtime, but this _____ (= possibilité) take several months to implement fully.

Réponse : _____

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DEVOIR MAISON

Nom & Prénom : _____

Groupe : _____

Date rendu : _____



Complète avec le modal le plus approprié.



Correction envoyée via WhatsApp la semaine prochaine.

1. You _____ smoke in the building — it's absolutely forbidden.
→ _____
2. She _____ speak four languages — she's trilingual.
→ _____
3. He _____ have left already — his coat is gone.
→ _____
4. You _____ revise your notes before the presentation.
→ _____
5. I _____ attend the team dinner tomorrow — it's optional.
→ _____
6. They _____ have made an error — the results don't add up.
→ _____
7. You _____ worry too much — everything will work out.
→ _____
8. She _____ have passed the test — she's celebrating!
→ _____
9. We _____ submit the report now — the deadline is next week.
→ _____
10. He _____ have called me — I missed an important update.
→ _____
11. Students _____ enter the clean room without protective gear.
→ _____
12. She _____ (ability) solve complex differential equations.
→ _____
13. The device _____ be connected before switching it on — safety requirement.
→ _____
14. You _____ have come so early — we weren't ready yet.
→ _____
15. He _____ be the engineer who designed this — look at the blueprint signature.
→ _____

Score : _____ / 15 points